

cent of the vote share. While the BSP still has influence over the (Scheduled Caste) Satnami community in central Chhattisgarh, the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) is emerging as a new player. It is eyeing tribal Christian votes in the north and south, reasoning it could wrest them from the Congress, which allegedly did not defend the community when it faced right-wing attacks. And a new formation has come as the X factor—the Sarv Adivasi Samaj, an umbrella organisation of tribal groups led by former Union minister Arvind Netam, expected to field around 50 candidates. The pie, therefore, is shaped differently. And how the roulette may spin is far from settled.

"In 2018, the SC vote moved to the JCC, but a number of OBC groups moved to the Congress from the BJP. Now it seems two-thirds of the seven per cent JCC vote share from 2018 would go to the Congress, the remaining to the BJP. The gap between vote shares would reduce," says political analyst Sudeep Shrivastava. Senior journalist Diwakar Muktibodh adds, "While the CM's popularity and its initiatives will help the Congress, the BJP has managed to raise issues and mobilise workers through direct involvement of central leaders." A time, then, to spread the bets. ■

BATTLE FOR RAJASTHAN

CROWN LOOKS FOR HEAD

By Rohit Parihar

It will be his tenth trip to Rajasthan in as many months. But when Prime Minister Narendra Modi addresses a rally in Jaipur on September 25, as he is expected to, nearly two months would have elapsed since his previous touchdown. It was on July 27, in Sikar, that Modi last touched base with voters of the poll-bound state. The BJP naturally eyes a chance to dislodge the Ashok Gehlot government at the hustings, just about eight weeks away now. But hobbled by a lack of clarity on the chief ministerial candidate, it had crafted its campaign around a highly personalised, direct voter outreach by the PM. And if that didn't accelerate to the degree one may have anticipated by the fearsome pace it took off with, it's a reflection of that same inner dilemma about leadership.

Given this indeterminate status, the BJP has worked out a two-pronged strategy. One, discrediting the Gehlot-led Congress regime. Two, seeking to mobilise popular support through a yatra for *parivartan*, or change, which it launched hurriedly from the four corners of the state on September 2. The party hopes Modi's visit will come as a redemptive grand touch to those roadshows, which have otherwise seen a poor turnout.



ANI

REMOTE CONTROL BJP president J.P. Nadda (centre) with former Rajasthan CM Vasundhara Raje and party's state chief C.P. Joshi in Jaipur, July 16

Reason: the confusion at the top has filtered all the way down, candidate selection has been delayed, which has led to a deficit in local ground-level support.

The first imperative, meanwhile, had been addressed by the central agencies going into overdrive, unearthing corruption in various state departments. In the latest in a string of such seizures, the Enforcement Directorate in raids conducted